RECOVERY SCAM RED FLAGS

Before-you-pay checklist: read this before anyone "gets your coins back"

Lost crypto once? Scammers watch for posts like yours and reply as "recovery agents." Check every offer against this list. One box ticked means stop. Two or more means it is almost certainly the same crew.

- [ ] **They contacted you first**
  A DM, comment reply, or call after you posted about a loss. Real help does not cold-message victims.
- [ ] **They want a fee up front**
  Retainer, "unlock tax," gas fee, or verification deposit. All the same trick.
- [ ] **A second fee shows up**
  Paid once? A bigger "release" fee comes next. Every new ask is part of the scam.
- [ ] **They ask for your recovery phrase**
  No trace or investigation ever needs your 12 or 24 words or remote access to your device.
- [ ] **They guarantee your money back**
  Nobody honest can promise recovery after a theft.
- [ ] **They say they work with the FBI or a court**
  Real agencies do not partner with private recovery firms or charge you in crypto.
- [ ] **They want crypto, gift cards, or a wire**
  These payments are picked because they cannot be reversed.
- [ ] **They rush you or say keep it secret**
  A closing "window" and "don't tell your bank" are pressure tactics.

WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

1. Stop all payments and stop replying to strangers who offer help.
2. Save screenshots, wallet addresses, and transaction IDs.
3. Report it: ic3.gov (FBI), reportfraud.ftc.gov, and your local police.
4. Call your exchange or bank fraud team using the number on their official site.
5. Move anything left to a new wallet with a fresh recovery phrase.

Rule of thumb: anyone who charges first to get your coins back is the scam.

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